

MAINS MASTER PROGRAM (MMP) 2024
POLITY – 11
ROLE OF CIVIL SERVICES IN A DEMOCRACY

Civil Service

➤ **What is civil service?**

- ✓ Civil service refers to **the body of government officials** who are employed in **civil capacities** and are responsible for the **administration of public policies and programs**.
- ✓ Civil servants are **non-political, professional employees** who work in various departments and agencies of the government at different levels—central, state, and local.
- ✓ Their primary role is **to implement government policies** and provide services to the public **efficiently and effectively**.

➤ **Features of Civil Service**

✓ **Body of Professionals**

- Civil servants are expected to possess the necessary skills, knowledge, and expertise to perform their duties competently.
- They undergo rigorous training and recruitment processes to ensure they meet the standards required for public service.

✓ **Impartial selection**

- Civil servants are recruited through merit-based selection process which is carried out by specialised recruiting agency
- Example – **UPSC, SPSC, SSC etc.**

✓ **Principle of Neutrality & Anonymity**

- Civil service is politically neutral, meaning **civil servants do not engage in partisan politics** and serve the government of the day.
- This **neutrality ensures continuity and stability** in governance, regardless of changes in political leadership.
- Anonymity in civil service refers to the principle that **civil servants operate behind the scenes** and do not **receive public recognition or scrutiny** for their work

✓ **Principle of Chain of Command**

- Civil service follows a rigid hierarchy in the way the decisions are made and executed.

✓ **Regular Remuneration**

- Civil service provides an opportunity for career service providing them appropriate remuneration through out their career and requires exclusivity in service.

✓ **Principle of Accountability**

- Civil servants are accountable to the public and the government for their actions and decisions.
- Mechanisms such as audits, reviews, and performance evaluations are in place to ensure accountability.

✓ **Code of Conduct** Civil servants provide a wide range of services to the public, including education, healthcare, transportation, and social welfare.

- Civil servants are regulated a set of guidelines in the form of do's & don'ts that regulate their official conduct inside and outside the organisation.

➤ **Functions of Civil Service in India**

✓ **Policy Implementation & Formulation**

- Civil servants are responsible for putting government policies into action.
- They ensure that policies are executed effectively and efficiently, translating legislative decisions into practical outcomes.
- Example – National Health Policy, National Forest Policy, Population control Policy etc.

✓ **Public Service Delivery**

- Civil servants provide a wide range of services to the public, including education, healthcare, transportation, and social welfare.

✓ **Regulation and Oversight**

- Civil servants enforce laws and regulations, ensuring compliance and maintaining public order.
- They oversee various sectors, such as finance, environment, and industry, to protect public interests.
- Example – RBI, IRDA, TRAI, CCI etc.

✓ **Advisory Role**

- Civil servants advise elected officials on policy matters, providing expert analysis and recommendations.
- They conduct research, gather data, and present evidence-based information to support decision-making.

✓ **Administrative Management**

- Civil servants manage the day-to-day operations of government departments and agencies.
- They handle budgeting, human resources, procurement, and other administrative functions.

✓ **Disaster Management**

- The civil service has an important role in preventive as well as rehabilitation measures during natural disaster.
- Example – District administration, NDRF etc.

✓ **Ensuring Continuity and Stability**

- Civil service provides continuity and stability in governance, even as political leadership changes.
- This stability is essential for the consistent implementation of long-term policies and programs.

✓ **Upholding the Rule of Law**

- Civil servants enforce laws and regulations, ensuring that public administration operates within the legal framework.

- They help maintain order, justice, and fairness in society.

➤ **Relationship between Political Executive & Civil Servants**

- ✓ The relationship between the **political executive & civil servants** has to be defined by principle of **neutrality & anonymity**.
- ✓ **Principle of Neutrality**
 - Independence of thought & objective
 - Honest & Objective advice
 - Speaking truth to power
- ✓ **Factors that affect Neutrality**
 - Fear of Repercussion
 - Lack of Pride & Poor Work culture
 - Political & Bureaucratic corruption
 - Lack of values & training
- ✓ **Problems associated with lack of Neutrality**
 - Erodes Trust between Political & Permanent Executive
 - Affects the developmental process
 - Erodes civil service values – Integrity; Honesty; Esprit de corps; spirit of service etc.
- ✓ **Principle of Anonymity**
 - Shielding from Public and Political Pressure
 - Ministerial Responsibility
 - Impartial Implementation of Policies
- ✓ **Way forward**
 - Cooling off Period [Election Commission of India]
 - Code of Ethics for Civil Servants [2nd ARC]
 - Civil Services Board [2nd ARC]
 - Strengthening Oversight Mechanisms [Example – Audit, Lokpal, CVC etc.]
 - Encouraging Whistleblowing

➤ **Traditional Bureaucratic Structure & Culture in Civil Service**

- ✓ **Hierarchical Structure**
 - Traditional bureaucracies tend to have a rigid hierarchical structure with **centralized decision-making**, where higher officials have most of the authority.
- ✓ **Red Tape and Bureaucratic Rigidity**
 - Bureaucratic procedures are often characterized by **excessive paperwork, formalities, and rigid processes**.
- ✓ **Lack of Accountability and Transparency**
 - Traditional bureaucratic systems may **lack transparency and clear accountability mechanisms**, leading to inefficiencies and corruption.
- ✓ **Conservatism and Resistance to Change**

- A conservative culture within the bureaucracy may **resist innovative approaches and changes** to traditional practices.
- ✓ **Attitude of master & not servant**
 - The superiority attitude of the civil service is an unfortunate hang over of colonial legacy which has to be done away with.
- ✓ **Poor Work culture**
 - The work culture of an organisation includes a set of variables like the attitudes of the officials, values they possess, communication & leadership styles etc.
 - Today most of the public office do not have a favourable work culture for promoting efficient public service delivery.
- ✓ **Generalist Dominance**
 - The generalist occupies the top position in most departments in India as critics say this as one of the reasons for lack of efficiency in civil service today as the nature of service are becoming more specialised today
- **Lateral Entry in Civil Service**
 - ✓ **What is lateral Entry?**
 - Lateral entry in civil service refers to the practice of **recruiting professionals and experts from outside the traditional civil service cadre** into mid-level and senior positions within the government.
 - This approach aims to infuse **fresh perspectives, specialized skills, and domain expertise into the bureaucracy, which can enhance the efficiency and effectiveness** of public administration.
 - ✓ **Advantages of lateral entry**
 - **Specialisation & domain expertise**
 - ❖ Lateral entrants bring specialized knowledge and skills from their respective fields.
 - **Innovation and Fresh Perspectives**
 - ❖ Lateral entrants can introduce new ideas and approaches to problem-solving, breaking the monotony of traditional bureaucratic methods.
 - **Bridging Skill Gaps**
 - ❖ Lateral entry can address specific skill shortages within the civil service. Recruiting data scientists and IT experts to bolster digital initiatives and e-governance projects.
 - **Enhanced Accountability and Performance Culture**
 - ❖ The inclusion of professionals accustomed to performance-based environments can promote a culture of accountability and results orientation in the civil service.
 - **Foster competitive spirit**
 - ❖ It can infuse competition between the permanent cadre officers & lateral entrants on the positive side.

✓ **Disadvantages of lateral entry**

- **Compromising on civil service values**
 - ❖ The lateral entrants may not be trained and aware of the certain important civil service values like neutrality & impartiality.
- **Creation of spoil system in India**
 - ❖ Spoil system in some countries like USA is based on the principle of appointment to higher services as a reward for loyalty rather than merit.
- **Lack of field experience**
 - ❖ The lateral entrants may lack the field experience which is crucial for them to provide the services effectively.
- **Low efficiency may be correlated to environmental factors rather than personal factors.**
 - ❖ Lateral entry assumes that poor efficiency in civil service is due to lack of expertise or efficiency of the civil servant rather than taking environmental factors like political interference, corruption etc.
- **Resistance from Existing Bureaucrats**
 - ❖ Existing civil servants may resist the inclusion of lateral entrants, perceiving them as threats to their career progression and status.

➤ **Recommendations for Effective Lateral Entry**

- ✓ Transparent and Merit-Based Selection [2nd ARC – Institutionalization of Lateral entry]
- ✓ **Domain specific training and experience through deputation to private Sector / PSUs**
- ✓ Proper Induction and Training
- ✓ Building a Collaborative Culture
- ✓ Monitoring and Evaluation of performance.

➤ **Issues & problems in Civil Service in India**

- ✓ **Cultural factors / Issues**
 - Resistance to Change
 - Poor Work culture
 - Patronage and Nepotism
- ✓ **Political Factors / Issues**
 - Political interference
 - Lack of reforms
 - Lack of Neutrality
- ✓ **Operational factors / Issues**
 - Resource Constraints
 - Corruption and Lack of Accountability
 - Inadequate Training and Capacity Building
 - Poor performance management system
- ✓ **Structural factors / Issues**

- Rigid Hierarchical Structure
- Bureaucratic Red Tape
- Inadequate Human Resource Management

➤ Civil Service Reforms

- ✓ Civil service reforms refer to the deliberate and systematic efforts to improve the efficiency, effectiveness, responsiveness, and accountability of the civil service.
- ✓ These reforms aim to transform the structure, processes, culture, and functioning of the civil service to better meet the needs of the public and adapt to changing social, economic, and political environments.
- ✓ **Reforms suggested by 2nd ARC**
 - **Capacity building**
 - ❖ Mandatory training at all levels.
 - ❖ Mid-career training
 - ❖ Few specialised institutes to be developed through proper infrastructure. Example – LBSNAA, SVPNPA for Group A officers. ISTM (Institute of Secretariat Training and Management) – for Group B and C officers.
 - ❖ mid-level management – specialisation/domain specific training
 - ❖ Deputation to outside government agencies
 - **Motivating civil servants**
 - ❖ National Awards for good works. Example – PM award for excellence in Public Administration.
 - ❖ Priority in foreign assignment
 - **Accountability (2 reviews)**
 - ❖ end of 14 years of service
 - ❖ end of 20 years of service - compulsory retirement.
 - **Disciplinary proceedings of Civil Servants**
 - ❖ Amendment to Art. 311
 - **Civil Service Bill should be introduced**
 - ❖ Code of ethics for civil servants.
 - ❖ Integrity, impartiality, commitment, accountability, devotion to duty, exemplary behaviour.
 - ❖ Recruitment and service conditions
 - ❖ Independent audit of these recruitment process.
 - ❖ Appointment to higher levels – Central Civil Service Authority (CCSA)
- ✓ **Mission Karmayogi [National Program for Civil Service Capacity Building]**
 - **Objective**
 - ❖ aims to transform capacity-building in the bureaucracy through institutional and process reforms
 - ❖ 'Mission Karmayogi' envisages to prepare Indian civil servants for the future by making them more creative, constructive, imaginative, innovative, proactive,

professional, progressive, energetic, enabling, transparent and technology enabled.

- **Focus Areas**
 - ❖ Domain Knowledge & Administrative capacity
 - ❖ Right Recruitment & capacity building
 - ❖ Specialist to be given more role
 - ❖ lateral induction of personnel from private sector
- **Plan for implementation**
 - ❖ Integrated government online training [iGOT platform]
 - ❖ Evaluation of officers based on the courses
 - ❖ Assignment of roles & responsibilities

Questions

1. Civil service reforms are essential for creating a modern, efficient, and responsive public administration system. In this context suggest suitable reforms for civil service [10]
2. Lateral entry in civil service can bring significant benefits in terms of expertise, innovation, and improved performance, but at the same time it brings challenges related to integration, cultural fit, and potential conflicts of interest. Comment [10]
3. What in your opinion are the various traditional bureaucratic structure & culture that affects the effective and efficient functioning of civil service today in India? [10]
4. What do you understand by principle of neutrality & anonymity in civil service? What factors do you think affect these values in civil service in the present context and suggest ways to control them. [10]
5. What do you understand by civil service? Do you agree with the view that, civil service contribute significantly to the socio-economic development and stability of a nation? [10]